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(MIMO) signal creation and analysis are needed to test the WiMax and LTE systems effectively," says Dogra.

Recently, a lot of research has taken place in medical electronics. It's a new topic added to many universities' curriculum. Signals from human body are very small in magnitude, giving rise to small-signal detection and measurement. To measure these signals, you need to install equipment that are highly sensitive and responsive. High-resolution digital storage oscilloscopes are suitable for medical electronics labs.

Moore's law states that the number of transistors that can easily fit in an IC approximately doubles every two years. There are forums that support research on very large-scale integration (VLSI) in universities and industries. Manufacturers like Agilent Technologies work closely in providing high-end equipment and simulation tools for the VLSI labs.

Microwave technology has made a great impact on various consumer products. A microwave lab is equipped with microwave anechoic chamber, vector network analyser, noise figure meter and microwave test accessories along with EDA tools and simulation software.

Money matters!

While the manufacturers realise the need for economical solutions for academia, there are many programmes run by them to encourage the use of latest and upgraded equipment in the labs. "Manufacturers offer attractive exchange and upgradation schemes to the institutes so that they can have latest equipment," shares Singh. He adds, "Normally, when the syllabus changes, institutes go for upgrading

Upcoming labs with special requirements

1. Nano technology
2. Security technology
3. Communications
4. Medical electronics
5. VLSI
6. Microwave



A modern lab set-up

their labs."

"Government funding was always available for setting up new labs, but recently the government has started supporting upgradation of academic labs too," shares Kwatra.

Prof. Khanna from Thapar University shares, "A lab can be privately funded by the institutes. There are government support programmes like Modernisation and Removal of Obsolescence Scheme (MODROBS) and Research Promotion Scheme (RPS) of AICTE and Funds for Improvement of Science and Technology (FIST) scheme of Department of Science and Technology (DST) that help in upgrading labs in the technical institutes for undergraduate (UG) and postgraduate (PG) levels." The University Grant Commission (UGC) has also started funding new postgraduate programmes in technical institutes.

"Usually, industries do their research and development activity either in collaboration with an R&D organisation or with an academic institute. In such cases, the industry sponsors similar equipment to the academia to receive better and reliable results for their easier implementation and benefits," says Dr Maheshwari.

Technical institutes, funding bodies, government and the industry all are working towards creating more practical engineers. So what are you waiting for? Analyse where you are stuck and join the initiative! ●

The author is a senior technology journalist at EFY